

Telehealth and Virtual Care Coverage Policy 2026

Effective January 1, 2026 | Confidential · For Internal Use

1. Scope and Eligibility

This policy governs telehealth and virtual care services covered under all plan types including Commercial, Medicare Advantage, and Medicaid plans effective January 1, 2026. Telehealth services are covered for eligible members who receive care from credentialed providers using audio-video technology or, in limited cases, audio-only when video is not feasible.

2. Covered Telehealth Services

The following services are covered via telehealth: Primary care visits (CPT 99202-99215), Mental health therapy (CPT 90832-90837), Psychiatry consultations (CPT 90791, 90792), Specialist consultations, Follow-up appointments, Chronic disease management, and Medication management. Telehealth services are reimbursed at the same rate as in-person visits for equivalent service codes.

3. Medicare Advantage Telehealth Expansion

Effective January 1, 2026, Medicare Advantage members have expanded telehealth access with no geographic restrictions. Members may use telehealth services from any location including their home. No prior authorization is required for routine telehealth visits under Medicare Advantage plans. This expansion aligns with CMS telehealth flexibilities extended through December 31, 2026.

4. Audio-Only Services

Audio-only services are covered for members without access to video technology. Covered audio-only CPT codes include 99441-99443 for telephone evaluation and management. Providers must document reason for audio-only modality. Audio-only services are limited to 10 per calendar year per member for commercial plans.

5. Provider Requirements

Telehealth providers must be credentialed and licensed in the member's state of residence. Providers must use HIPAA-compliant telehealth platforms. Prescribing via telehealth is permitted for most medications with the exception of controlled substances, which require an in-person evaluation as per DEA regulations.

6. Billing and Documentation

Telehealth claims must include place of service code 02 (Telehealth provided other than in patient's home) or 10 (Telehealth provided in patient's home). Modifier GT or 95 must be appended to CPT codes for audio-video services. Modifier 93 applies to audio-only services. Failure to include appropriate modifiers will result in claim rejection.

7. Exclusions

The following services are not covered via telehealth: Physical examinations requiring hands-on assessment, Laboratory tests and imaging services, Surgical procedures, Emergency department visits, Anesthesia services, and Dental or vision services. Members requiring these services must present in person.